

Ports of Plague

A game of trade, survival and conscience during the Black Death, 1347–1353 · Rule Book · 1–6 players (bots can fill the other houses) · about 15–60 minutes · ages 14+

HISTORICAL BACKGROUND

In 1346 plague broke out among the Mongol army besieging the Genoese port of Caffa on the Black Sea ^{TR-02}. Italian merchant ships carried it to Constantinople, then to Sicily in October 1347 ^{TR-06}, and from there along the trade routes to almost every corner of Europe by 1353 ^{TL-02 TR-10}. Somewhere between a third and 60 percent of Europeans died; historians still debate the number ^{DB-01}.

You lead a merchant family in one of Europe's great trading cities. Trade makes you rich, but every ship can carry the plague. The game follows the real timeline: the plague reaches each city in the half-year it really did. Along the way you will face the same choices real people faced: to flee or to stay, to trust physicians who could not cure the disease ^{ME-08}, to answer the Church's call, to obey or ignore England's wage laws ^{EC-05}, and whether to stand up for neighbors falsely blamed for the plague ^{SO-07}.

OBJECTIVE

A standard game lasts **12 rounds** of half a year each, from Late 1347 to Early 1353; **Quick Play** covers the same years in 4 rounds of a year and a half. With **pre-plague rounds** switched on (the default), the game starts earlier: 2 extra rounds in the standard game (Late 1346 and Early 1347) and 1 in Quick Play, to set up trade before the plague arrives. When it ends, the house with the highest **Legacy score** wins. Legacy combines **Wealth**, **Family** and **Reputation**, plus a **Balance bonus** equal to your weakest of the three. A balanced house usually beats a greedy one. No one is ever knocked out of the game.

COMPONENTS (ON SCREEN)

- **The map:** 45 real cities, from Lisbon, Dublin and Oslo to Cairo, Aleppo, Trebizond and Pskov, joined by sea routes (solid lines) and land routes (dashed lines). Each route shows its base value.
- **City markers:** *Safe* (plain). *Safe* cities can also be *Threatened* (dashed orange ring: a neighbouring city is Stricken). *Stricken* cities have a red ring, a hatched centre and 1–3 severity pips; *Aftermath* cities have a grey ring and a ☠ mark.

- **House crests:** each player has a color and a shape (circle, square, triangle, diamond, hexagon or star). A banner by a city is a trading post; the number on it shows how many family members live there.
- **Dice:** turn-order, profit, contagion, severity and mortality dice, all rolled by the computer with animation.
- **Cards:** dated *Chronicle* cards, a shuffled deck of 34 *Event* cards, and a personal deck of 22 *Fortune* cards.
- **Tracks and Journal:** florins (*f*), reputation (0–20), family, a live Legacy score, and the Historian's Journal of every fact you meet, with its source.

SETUP

- Choose 2–6 houses, each played by a person or a bot (see *Bots* below; at least 1 person). Each house picks a house name and a different home city (Venice, Genoa, Florence, Marseille, Barcelona, London, Bruges or Lübeck). Colors and crests are assigned by seat.
- Each house starts with **12 florins**, **5 family members** in the home city, **7 reputation** and **one trading post** in the home city. To balance their routes and plague dates, home cities start with slightly different amounts of money, shown on the setup screen.
- Choose **Standard** or **Quick Play**, and a difficulty: **Apprentice** (gentler plague, hints all game), **Chronicler** (standard) or **Great Mortality** (severity rolls +1, contagion risk +1).
- Two options, both on unless you switch them off: **Pre-plague rounds** (see *How a Round Works*) and the **turn timer**: each house has **30 seconds** per turn. The clock stops while cards and dice are on screen. When time runs out, any card still waiting is declined (a wage law is obeyed) and the next house plays.
- **Bots (optional):** any house can be played by a computer. Set *Played by* to *A bot* on the setup screen (on several devices, press *Add a bot* in the lobby) and choose its skill: **Easy** (a simple style, often makes mistakes), **Medium** (sometimes slips) or **Hard** (weighs every choice by Legacy points). At least one house must be played by a person, so you can play alone against bots. A bot plays by the same rules and sees only what a person sees on screen. Its moves are shown one at a time, and cards during its turn go on by themselves after 8 seconds.

- Caffa and Tana begin Stricken. Each house rolls a die: the highest goes first and tied houses roll again. **This turn order stays the same all game.**
- **Playing on several devices (optional):** choose *Everyone on their own device*. The big screen shows the map, the dice and every card, plus a room code. Each player joins on a phone, tablet or computer with *Join a game* and the code, and takes their turn there. On a card, anyone can press *Next*. Each device can also show the rules, the Journal, the map and the current card. A player who has to go can press *Leave game*: their house sits out (turns skipped, card offers turned down) until they join again with the same code.

HOW A ROUND WORKS

Every round has four phases:

1. **Chronicle.** The date advances. The plague reaches every city whose real arrival date falls in this round; each becomes Stricken and rolls severity. Then the round's dated Chronicle cards are read (up to four to a page).
2. **Event.** One Event card is drawn. If it offers a choice, each player decides at the start of their own turn.
3. **Actions.** Players take turns in the fixed order, each with **2 action points (AP)** (3 in Quick Play). Most actions take 1 AP, but **Open Trading Post** and **Move Family** take 2. A pass-the-device screen appears between turns.
4. **Plague & upkeep.** Family members in Stricken cities roll for survival. Cities Stricken for 2 half-years move to Aftermath. Land wages are paid, loans that are due are repaid, and partnerships and closed gates that have run their course end.

Quick Play: each round covers three half-years at once, so arrivals and Chronicle cards for all three are read, and the plague phase happens three times (three survival rolls).

Pre-plague rounds: in 1346 and early 1347 the plague has only reached Caffa and Tana on the Black Sea ^{TR-02 TL-13}. There is no Event card and no survival roll, only upkeep, and opening a trading post costs 3f less, so houses can set up their trade before the plague sails west.

ACTIONS

Spend your action points on the actions below, in any order. Most take **1 AP**. **Open Trading Post** and **Move Family** are bigger undertakings and take **2 AP**: in the standard game that is your whole turn, and in Quick Play it leaves 1 AP. Take a Loan and Propose a Partnership take no AP. A Fortune or Event card that makes an action free also means it takes no AP.

ACTION (KEY)	COST	WHAT IT DOES
Ship Goods (1)	1 AP	Choose one of your trading posts that has not shipped this round and a route leaving it. Earn the route value + the profit die (1–6) + 1 if a family member lives at that post + 2 if the destination is in Aftermath, minus 1 wage if the origin is in Aftermath. If the origin is Stricken, the contagion die is rolled too (see <i>Plague</i>). You may pay 2f more to hold the ship offshore (see <i>Plague</i>).
Open Trading Post (2)	2 AP + 8f	Open a post in a city connected by a route to one of your posts. It cannot be a Stricken city. You may own at most 6 posts.
Move Family (3)	2 AP	Move up to 2 family members from one of your cities or your Country Estate to another. Fleeing (leaving a Stricken city) costs 1 reputation. Family at the Estate is safe from the plague, but earns no family bonus.
Prepare Household (4)	1 AP + 2f	Pick a city where your family lives. They shut themselves in and stockpile food, the way some families isolated themselves in 1348 ^{SO-05} . This round their survival rolls there get +1.
Consult Physician (5)	1 AP + 2f	Pick a city where your family lives. You learn a real remedy of the time, and none of them worked ^{ME-06} . Basic nursing gives a slim chance: this round, the first family member there who would die rolls again and survives on a 6.
Charity & Piety (6)	1 AP + 4f	Fund a hospital, a confraternity or your parish church: +1 reputation. Once per turn. The house in last place pays 1f less.
Arrange a Marriage (7)	1 AP + 6f	Only in a city in Aftermath where you have a post and family: +1 family member there. After the epidemic, survivors married and many children were born ^{SO-12} . Your family cannot grow beyond 5. Once per turn.

ACTION (KEY)	COST	WHAT IT DOES
Buy Abandoned Land (8)	1 AP + 6f	Only near a city in Aftermath where you have a post, one holding per city. So many farmers died that fields lay empty ^{EC-02} . Each holding is worth 2 Wealth points at the end, but workers were scarce ^{EC-03} : pay 1f per holding in every plague phase, or lose 1 reputation if you cannot.
Take a Loan (9)	no AP	Borrow 6f now and repay 8f in the plague phase of the next round. Florence's great banks had failed just before the plague ^{EC-01} . If you cannot pay in full, you pay what you have and lose 2 reputation. One loan at a time; not in the final round.
Propose a Partnership (0)	no AP	Offer another house a partnership (once per turn). They accept or decline at the start of their next turn. Until the end of the next round, when either partner ships to a city where the other has a post, the shipper earns 1f more and the partner 1f, like the linked trade networks of Italy and the Hanseatic League ^{TR-04} . One partner at a time.
Close Your Gates (G)	1 AP, -1 reputation	Pick a city that is not Stricken where you have a post and family. Until the end of the next round, rival houses cannot open a post there and earn 1f less shipping to it. Frightened towns really did turn strangers away ^{SO-11} . One city at a time.
End Turn (E)	–	Unused action points are lost.

The game blocks illegal moves and explains why, for example: "Florence is Stricken: its gates are closed to new trading posts."

THE PLAGUE

- **Historical spread.** At the start of each round, the plague reaches the cities it really reached in that half-year. The date and its source are shown in a Historical Note.
- **Severity.** Each newly Stricken city rolls the severity die: 1–2 **Light** (1 pip), 3–4 **Heavy** (2), 5–6 **Devastating** (3). Hard-hit Tuscany and Catalonia (Florence, Pisa, Barcelona) add 1; Flanders (Bruges) subtracts 1 ^{CI-06}. On Apprentice difficulty, every roll is 1 lower (never below Light).

- **Contagion.** When you ship from a Stricken city, the contagion die is rolled. If it is equal to or lower than that city's severity, the cargo is **infected**: you earn only half the profit (rounded down) and lose 1 reputation, as ports blamed plague ships ^{CI-11}. If the destination is Safe and the plague really reached it in the *next* round, it becomes Stricken now, 1 round early. If the destination is already Stricken, its severity rises by 1 (maximum 3). Otherwise the infection dies out. **Holding a ship offshore** (+2f) means an infected cargo still earns half, but you lose no reputation and it cannot spread. By 1348 Venice made arriving ships wait before sailors could land ^{ME-12}; formal quarantine only came in 1377 ^{ME-14}.
- **Survival.** In the Plague phase, each family member in a Stricken city rolls the mortality die, adding +1 if the household was prepared. If the result is equal to or lower than the severity, that family member dies.
- **The last heir.** A house's last family member never dies; a distant cousin inherits. No one is eliminated.
- **Inheritance.** For each family member lost, the house inherits 3f. Survivors really did inherit the property of the dead ^{EC-10}.
- **Aftermath.** After 2 half-years a Stricken city enters Aftermath. Workers are scarce and prices are high ^{EC-03} ^{EC-04}: shipping *from* it costs a wage, and shipping *to* it earns a bonus.

CHRONICLE AND EVENT CARDS

- **Chronicle cards** are real, dated history and always appear in their round, for example the Ordinance of Labourers in Early 1349 ^{EC-05} and the Jubilee of 1350 ^{CH-08}.
- **Event cards** are drawn one per round from a shuffled deck of 34 (none in the pre-plague rounds), so each game is different. Some affect every house; some fall on one house chosen at random.
- **Fortune cards** are personal. You draw one whenever you roll a 6 on the profit die or open a new trading post: spice cargoes, extra action points, free posts, warnings of where the plague goes next, but also demanding workers, illness and nervous creditors.
- **Offers** ("Buy a Book of Hours?") are accepted or declined at the start of your turn (Fortune offers at once). Some offers are traps from history: the remedy seller's cure does nothing.

- **Wage laws.** If you own a post in England (London, Melcombe Regis, Bristol or York), choose: **Obey** (+1 reputation, but your English posts cannot ship this round, because workers refuse the old wages) or **Pay market wages** (roll a die: on 1–2 you are fined 3f). The real laws failed to hold wages down ^{EC-07}.
- **Persecution.** The game shows the persecution of Jewish communities because it really happened, and because the accusations were **false** and the violence **unjust** ^{SO-07 SO-09}. When it appears, any house may **Protect the Community** for 3f and 1 AP at the start of its turn, gaining 3 reputation. No house can ever gain anything from persecution. Whatever players choose, the city suffers unrest: shipments to or from it earn 1 less for 2 half-years. Pope Clement VI condemned the accusations, but his words had little effect far from Avignon ^{SO-08}.

SCORING AND WINNING

CATEGORY	POINTS
Wealth	1 per 6f (rounded down), plus 1 per trading post, plus 2 per land holding
Family	3 per surviving family member
Reputation	1 per reputation point up to 10, then 1 per 3 points above that (a spotless name matters, but only so much)
Balance bonus	Add your <i>lowest</i> of Wealth, Family and Reputation again

Highest Legacy wins. Ties go to higher reputation, then more family; if still tied, the houses share the victory.

Comebacks. From Late 1349 on (half-year 5 of the plague years), a house in last place that trails the leader by 6 or more Legacy points receives **Guild's Favor**: +1 AP. Inheritance, the Survivors Marry chronicle, weddings, loans and cheaper charity also help houses that fall behind.

QUICK REFERENCE

- **Round:** Chronicle → Event → Actions (2 AP each; 3 in Quick Play) → Plague & upkeep. Turn order never changes.
- **Timer:** 30 seconds per turn (optional; paused while cards are shown). **Pre-plague rounds** (optional): no Event card, no survival rolls, posts 3f cheaper.
- **Action points:** 1 AP per action · Open Trading Post 2 AP · Move Family 2 AP · Loan and Partnership 0 AP.

- **Ship:** route value + profit die + family 1 + Aftermath destination 2 – Aftermath wage 1. From a Stricken city: contagion die ≤ severity means infected (half profit, –1 reputation, may spread). Profit die 6: draw a Fortune card.
- **Survival:** mortality die (+1 if prepared) ≤ severity means the family member dies. The last heir always survives. Each loss inherits 3f.
- **Costs:** Post 8f · Prepare 2f · Physician 2f · Charity 4f · Protect 3f + 1 AP · Offshore +2f · Marriage 6f · Land 6f (+1f per half-year) · Loan +6f now, 8f next round · Gates –1 reputation.
- **Keys:** 1–6 actions · 7 marriage · 8 land · 9 loan · 0 partnership · G gates · E end turn · R rules · J journal · M sound · N music · Enter confirm · Esc cancel.

GLOSSARY

Aftermath	A city the plague has passed through, now short of workers and with high prices. ^{EC-02}
Bull (papal)	An official document from the pope, named after the metal seal attached to it. ^{CH-09}
Cog / galley	Kinds of merchant ship: cogs sailed the northern seas, galleys the Mediterranean. ^{TR-04 TR-06}
Flagellants	Penitents who marched between towns whipping themselves to beg God's mercy. ^{SO-02}
Florin (f)	A famous gold coin first minted in Florence in 1252. ^{EC-11}
Hanseatic League	A network of German trading cities and their ships in the North Sea and Baltic. ^{TR-04}
Humors	Body fluids that medieval doctors believed had to stay in balance. ^{ME-05}
Miasma	"Bad air," wrongly believed to cause the plague. ^{ME-04}
Quarantine	Isolation of travelers, first made law in Ragusa in 1377, after this game ends. ^{ME-14}
Stricken	A city where the plague is raging. Severity: Light, Heavy or Devastating.

Small grey codes such as TR-02 point to the sourced facts listed in the Historical Research Sheet. The in-game Rules screen shows exactly this text; both are generated from data/rulebook.json and data/config.json.